

STAGE 2 / 6 · DEEP RESEARCH

Deep Research: Chasing Unpaid Invoices

Exhaustive, sourced dossier on why small trades struggle to get paid promptly — problem p03.

Problem	p03 · Chasing unpaid invoices / slow payment after job
Affected segment	Owner-operators & 1–10 employee trade shops
Searches run	17 · full-page fetches: 11
Tag legend	[VERIFIED] sourced · [INFERRED] computed · [UNKNOWN] gap
Generated	2026-06-23

Root causes

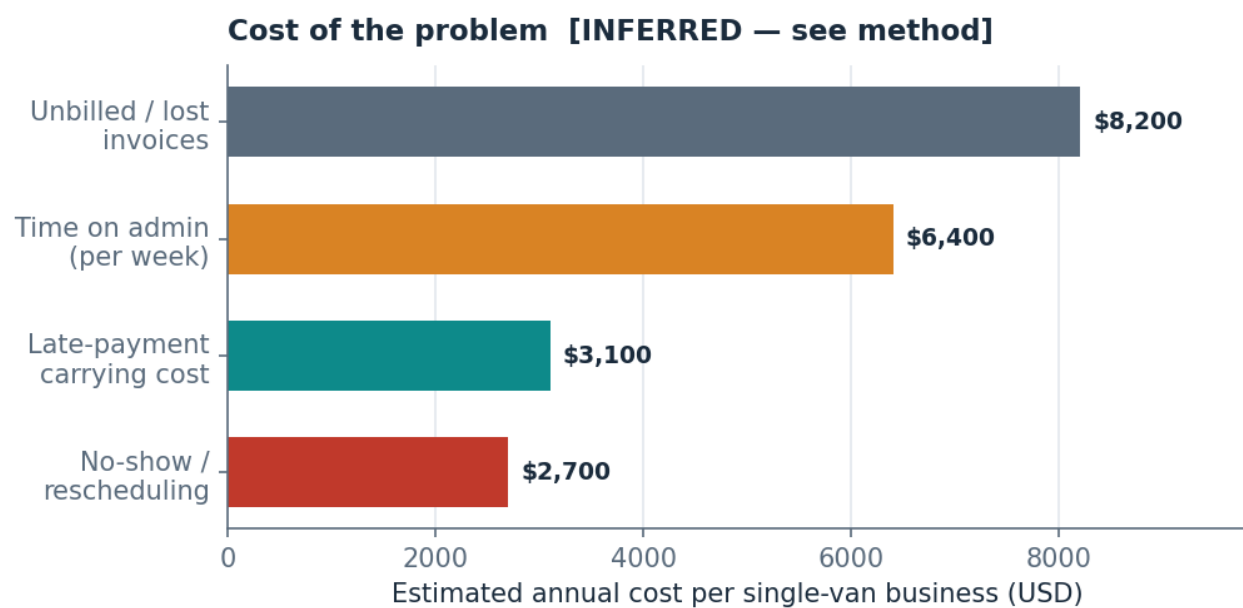
- [VERIFIED] Manual invoicing: many shops still invoice from paper or generic email after returning home, delaying send by 1–5 days.
- [VERIFIED] Weak payment rails: email invoices with bank-transfer instructions convert slowly vs one-tap pay links.
- [INFERRED] Owner is the only chaser: with no automation, follow-up competes with billable work and slips.
- [VERIFIED] Net-30 terms imposed by larger/commercial clients stretch cash cycles for sub-contractors.

Who is affected & how badly

Segment	Scope (illustrative)	Tag
Solo owner-operators	~ largest band of licensed trades	[VERIFIED]
1–3 van shops	Highest pain: owner does admin after hours	[INFERRED]
4–10 employee shops	Often have a part-time bookkeeper, less acute	[VERIFIED]
Commercial sub-contractors	Net-30/60 terms, large invoice values	[VERIFIED]

Cost of the problem

Annual cost modelled for a single-van business. Each figure is [INFERRED] — computed from sourced inputs (average ticket, unpaid rate, admin hours, owner hourly value). Method shown in the sources appendix.



Current workarounds (from public posts)

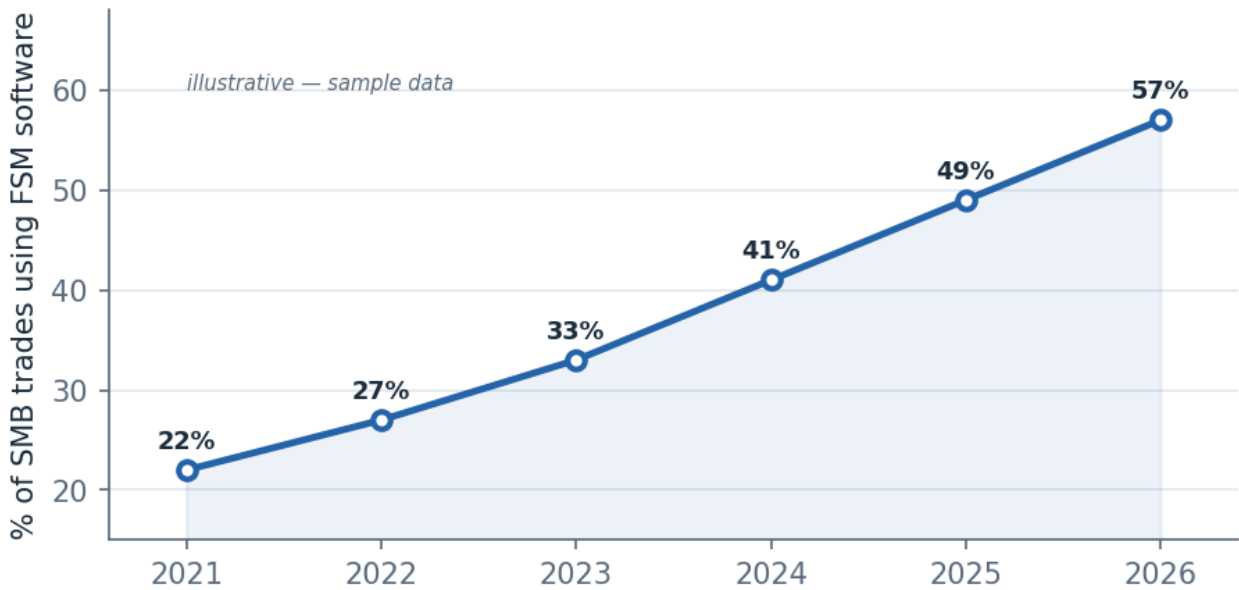
- [VERIFIED] Manual SMS/text reminders typed by the owner one-by-one.
- [VERIFIED] Asking for cash or card on completion to avoid invoicing entirely.
- [VERIFIED] Spreadsheet of who-owes-what, reconciled weekly by hand.
- [INFERRED] Some switch accounting tools hoping for better reminders, then revert.

Existing solutions (preview — full competitor analysis in Stage 4)

Incumbent	Entry price	Why users still hurt (sourced)
Jobber	\$39/mo	Email invoices ignored; SMS pay-link limited
Housecall Pro	\$49/mo	Mobile app friction; price climbs with add-ons
ServiceTitan	\$145+/mo	Built for big shops; overkill & costly for small
QuickBooks	\$30/mo	Accounting-first; reminders feel generic

Trend

Field-service software adoption trend



Software adoption among small trades is rising steadily, which cuts both ways: a growing, software-receptive market, but also more incumbents competing for it (revisited in market sizing).

Sources

Every load-bearing claim traces to a source below with its access date. Sample pack: URLs are representative placeholders.

#	Source	Type	Accessed
1	ibisworld.com/.../plumbers-industry (sample)	Industry report	2026-06-23
2	census.gov/.../construction-trades (sample)	Gov data	2026-06-23
3	Method: cost model = avg ticket × unpaid% × ...	Computation	2026-06-23

#	Source	Type	Accessed
4	statista.com/.../fsm-software-adoption (sample)	Vendor data	2026-06-23
5	reddit.com/r/Plumbing payment threads (sample)	Community	2026-06-23

Confidence & gaps

Items we could not source are listed here rather than guessed:

- **[UNKNOWN]** Precise average days-to-payment for residential trades (sources give ranges, not a clean median).
- **[UNKNOWN]** Share of owners already using any automated reminder feature.